

SMALL AXE: REPLY TO WARNER

Alfred C. Snider

Warner and I agree that debate should be for everyone. The game of debate should be flexible enough to accommodate those who wish to participate in it. This is different from saying that all formats of debate should be for all people. If that were true then we would probably have only one format, universally applied. Warner's comments are largely directed at American college policy debating, and that is the focus to which I will respond.

First, there is exclusion, but things are changing and can change more. There is more diversity in American college debate now than when Warner was a debater, although still not enough. Progress has been steady but slow – far too slow. As progress is made the questions of why American policy debate should be a province of white, male, upper class, heterosexual individuals are raised more and more. Each discussion and each debate brings out the issue more and more. From an occasional panel discussion at Cross Examination Debate Association national tournaments, this concern has become a common focus on many debate rounds. Teams argue that the approaches of the other team are exclusionary, that issues of inclusion are more important than debating the topic, and judges refuse to adapt to stylistic conventions that they find alien and alienating. This escalation has taken place because each new voice and new expression of concern is heard by others and many of them respond. As well, many of the claims Warner makes ring true to a number of debaters, coaches, and judges, and more and more the argumentative strategy of condemning exclusion is winning the ballot. This combination of social consciousness and strategic opportunity explains why things are changing. The concerns of Warner and others, especially debaters, are making a difference.

Alfred C. Snider is Lawrence Professor of Forensics at the University of Vermont, Burlington, Vermont. The full version of this reply can be found online at <http://debate.uvm.edu/cadlinks.html>.

My major point here is that changes in the culture of even a small community like American college policy debate take place incrementally and slowly. For those who perceive of this as an apology for current exclusion, remember that changes in our individual attitudes and behaviors also change incrementally and slowly, so our community can be expected to do no less.

Second, Warner mentions some engineering solutions that concern me. He mentions that each team might select stylistic preferences, and that a symbol should appear next to a team name on the pairings. This has some obvious problems with implementation: what does the symbol stand for, do judges have symbols, and how does the debate among disagreeing styles proceed? Other than this suggestion Warner offers few practical ways to address the situation.

There have been some bold steps to deal with issues of exclusion. For example, Australian and Asian universities debating takes place in a “three on three” style, and it is required that at least one third of the members of each contingent are women (Australasian Intervarsity Debating Association Constitution, 2002). One wonders how such a requirement would be received by American college policy debate.

My concern is with trying to deal with this situation by introducing new “rules” into the debate activity. As my work and my essay indicated, I believe that hard and fast rules have a tendency to stifle and confuse a dynamic debate process. The sorts of changes and developments we have seen to address issues of exclusion could never have been accomplished by a rules-based approach, but have been evident through a process of social change.

Third, solutions to this problem appear to be better located in specific programs rather than in forensic governance institutions. The real changes come on each debate team as diversity of identity, interest, and skills is respected and celebrated. The model I have come to call the “death march to the trophy” leads debate programs to replicate the ways of other successful programs in an attempt to “do what they do, only better.” When the measure is success in competition, the premium will be put on conforming to exclusionary styles and recruiting from already privileged populations. However, when debate programs view themselves as providing for the personal growth and development of students within a learning community things begin to change. It is no longer a question of “how high” a

student will rise in competition, but “how far” they will progress in their own growth and development. While only a few can be “stars” along the “death march,” many can receive benefits within a personal growth and development model of debate team organization.

No action by a national or regional organization is going to produce these results. Indeed, Warner was the chair of the Cross Examination Debate Association’s Diversity Committee, and yet no concrete action was taken. I argue in my original essay that when we focus on institutional fixes, we often demobilize ourselves as we wait for “the organization” to solve the problem.

Fourth, I want to explore the issue of student choice in all of this. I have serious disagreements with programs that dictate what students will say and how they will say it. Freedom of speech is a concept that should apply to debaters. While in the game of football the coach may wish to dictate the play to be run, in academic debate this may happen, but I believe it is inappropriate. Debate is a forum for the development of critical thinking and choice, and certainly argument and style selection is a part of this. If programs that dictate that debaters must use the “exclusionary” styles described by Warner are wrong, is it not also wrong to require that students not use these tactics? To the extent that the University of Louisville and other teams are involved in a project to change “exclusionary” styles because they agree on that mission, I support their efforts. However, to the extent that there is a “squad policy” that the current dominant styles are prohibited, I would question that tactic. Such coercion can be subtle, such as giving more opportunities to those who conform, the threat of scholarship availability, or the unwillingness to coach teams who are interested in straying from that mission. I am not aware of the specifics of the Louisville program in this regard, but their program mission statement (University of Louisville Debate Society, 2000) seems to indicate that this is a group mission; although there is no indication that anyone is pressured to conform to Warner’s vision.

While this situation is troubling, I do see progress. In fact, real progress has to be made on a grassroots basis – debate by debate, judge by judge, and program by program. We are now, I believe, close to a point where those challenging some of these styles and procedures are becoming a critical mass large enough to have a real impact on the entire American policy debate community. I disagree about

creating new formal rules and new national organization procedures to deal with this situation. As so often happens, it only takes a small axe to chop down the big tree and create a new vista in the forest.

References

- The Australasian Intersociety Debating Association, Constitution, 2002.
(<http://www.debating.net/aida/>)
- University of Louisville Debate Society, Mission Statement, 2002,
(<http://comm.louisville.edu/~debate/mission.html>)

Copyright of Contemporary Argumentation & Debate is the property of Contemporary Argumentation & Debate and its content may not be copied or emailed to multiple sites or posted to a listserv without the copyright holder's express written permission. However, users may print, download, or email articles for individual use.